

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

CFO-ORC FILE # 56-94-88AcceptedNEW STATE RECORD ☐UNUSUAL RECORD ☒**Species:** Purple Finch (*Carpodacus purpureus*)**Date:** 17 September 1994**Number seen:** one**Sex:** male (?)**Plumage:** non-ad. male**Locality:** Doudy Draw Open Space picnic area**Elevation:** 1744 m**Nearest town:** Eldorado Springs**County:** Boulder**Time observed:** mid-morning**Duration of observation:** two minutes

Description: I and two others heard an odd song, very vireo-like, and one person asked what it was. I thought that it sounded just like Purple Finch subsong (with which I am very familiar), but thought that that would be odd at Doudy, so, I responded that it was probably a Cassin's Finch, thinking that that species might have a subsong similar to Purple since their full songs are similar. The bird then stopped singing and I saw it flying toward us from down the draw. At that point, I saw that it was indeed one of the *Carpodacus* finches as it was heavily streaked below with a heavy bill and a fairly long, strongly-notched tail. It was also immediately apparent that it was not a House Finch as it had a whitish supercilium contrasting with a dark ear patch and dark crown. The bird then perched high in a willow in front of us, between us and the sun. Upon landing, it began giving typical Purple Finch call notes. Though the lighting prevented us from getting good looks at the plumage, the big-headed and long, notch-tailed look was evident. I told the other observers to listen carefully to the call note as it was quite distinctive.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration): The subsong given was typical for Purple Finch, consisting of two- and three-note phrases similar in cadence (though with longer intersong intervals) to a Red-eyed Vireo or an eastern Solitary Vireo, but with the quality and musicality of *Carpodacus*. The call note was a low-pitched, very dry "pik", given about 15 times from its perch near the top of one of the tall cottonwoods. This call note is decidedly unlike any other call note of any bird with which I am familiar.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly-appearing (and -sounding) species? I have seen 10,000+ Purple Finches all over the east and even some recently in the California Sierras where I worked in summer 1994 doing point counts (and where the PUFs sound slightly different). I have heard the call notes of Purple Finches on 100s of occasions and heard its subsong more than 20 times, mostly in Michigan. I have seen bazillions of House Finches and 100s of Cassin's Finches. I have lived with House Finches most of my birding career, so am familiar with (I think) all of its vocalizations. I have heard Cassin's Finches the least of the three North American *Carpodacus*, but I know its call note as noticeably different from that of Purple Finch.

Light conditions: Bird was mostly backlit when seen perched, but in flight, was in good light.

Optical equipment used: Leitz 10x40

Distance, and how estimated: estimated at 50 feet minimum distance

Other observers who saw the bird with you: Sharon Dooley and an unknown other

Other observers who saw the bird independently: none of which I am aware

If photographed, type of equipment and film: (How is this relevant?) bird was not photographed

List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

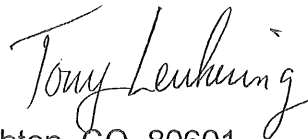
a) at time of observation: none

b) after observation: none

This report was written from notes made shortly after observation.

Reporting observer: Tony Leukering

Signature:

A handwritten signature in cursive script that reads "Tony Leukering".

Address: Colorado Bird Observatory, 13401 Piccadilly Road, Brighton, CO 80601

Date report was written: 29 November 1994